PERKALATE / SPORTS TEAMS

Why Sponsor Activations Miss Your Real Fans

Most sponsor activations reward whoever walks by. Here's why that weakens renewals, and what a better fan reward looks like.

Every season, a team's partnership group sells sponsor inventory with a promise: we'll put your brand in front of our fans. Then game day comes and the activation looks like this. A table on the concourse. A QR code on the big screen. A promo code read out during the broadcast. Whoever happens to be there gets the offer.

That works for awareness. It falls apart when the sponsor asks the question every renewal eventually turns on: did it do anything for us?

The anonymous fan problem

Most teams know a lot about a small slice of their fans: season ticket members, recent ticket buyers, people who signed up for the newsletter. They know very little about everyone else in the stands, and even less about what those fans do after they leave.

So activations default to broadcasting. The code goes to everyone, which means:

- Fans who would have bought from the sponsor anyway get a discount they didn't need.
- People with no real connection to the team, like a visiting group or a resale buyer, get the same offer as a ten year member.
- Codes end up on coupon sites within days, and redemption numbers stop meaning much.
- The sponsor sees a redemption count with no idea whether it came from your audience.

Why discounting to everyone hurts the team too

When a sponsor can't tie an activation to your fans, the value they assign to your audience drops. The renewal conversation turns into an argument about impressions and reach, numbers that are easy to inflate and hard to defend. A team that can show a sponsor real fans engaging with a real offer has a stronger story than a team with a bigger impression count.

There is a fan cost as well. Your most loyal supporters, the people who renew every year and travel to away games, get the same treatment as someone who wandered in. Rewards that ignore loyalty quietly tell loyal fans it doesn't count.

The data tension

The obvious fix is to hand sponsors a list of fans. Most teams rightly won't. Fans didn't sign up to have their names and emails passed to a bank, a beverage brand and a car dealer. Expectations around privacy keep rising, and one bad story about shared data can undo years of goodwill.

So teams get stuck between two bad options: broadcast offers that sponsors can't value, or data sharing that fans don't want.

What a better fan reward looks like

A good sponsor reward has four properties.

1. **It goes to verified fans.** Eligibility is based on something real, like being a season ticket member or a registered fan, not on being in the right seat when a code flashed on screen.
2. **The fan chooses to take part.** Explain the eligibility check and ask the fan before using information to make that decision.
3. **The sponsor sees results, not identities.** Totals for how many fans viewed, claimed and redeemed are enough to value the activation. Names aren't needed.
4. **It works where fans are.** At the stadium on game day, at the venue on days with no game, and online, because fandom doesn't stop at the gate.

None of this requires a new ticketing system. Start by writing down which fans you'd want a sponsor reward to reach, and what you'd want the sponsor to be able to report afterward. That short list usually shows how far current activations are from the goal, and which sponsors are most likely to pay for something better.

Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.